



PROTESTERS AT A STADIUM IN HYDERABAD

that the security forces, already stretched by the statehood campaign may be found wanting if the IPL is targeted.

Andhra Pradesh Chief Minister Konijeti Rosaiah called the IPL's exclusion of Hyderabad and Vizag, "an insult to the Government and the pride of my state... even after I assure security cover and take full responsibility for the smooth conduct of the matches". DC's Reddy hoped though that the situation could be reversed quickly towards Hyderabad and Visakhapatnam. "It does not take more than a couple of days to be ready considering we shifted in just 10 days to South Africa last year".

As DC moved its fixtures, the Shiv Sena changed its mind over attacking Australians (whose numbers coincidentally proliferate in the DC outfit). The Maharashtra Government too made the right noises. "We are not afraid of those repeatedly issuing threats. Adequate security would be provided to all Australian and IPL players," says Chief Minister Ashok Chavan.

The greater threat to the IPL in the wake of the Pune blast, is the fact that the event is now on the radar of Islamic terrorists. Intelligence inputs, some confirmed, warn of a threat to



LALIT MODI
Chairman, IPL

IPL FLASHPOINTS

Years of living dangerously

2008

- Harbhajan Singh slaps India teammate Sreesanth
- Bangalore Royal Challengers sack CEO and captain mid-season
- Serial blasts in Jaipur, home to Rajasthan Royals, during the season

2009

- IPL dates clash with Lok Sabha elections
- Differences with government on security issues
- Event moved within a fortnight to South Africa

2010

- Chargers' home matches moved from Hyderabad
- Shiv Sena refuses to welcome Aussie cricketers to IPL
- Pakistan players snubbed in an auction
- Al-Qaeda asks foreign competitors to abandon the event

Hyderabad from among 21 absconding suspects, of whom one is known to have returned to India. The city is a hub of several sleeper cells and terror modules of the Lashkar-e-Toiba and Harkat-ul-Jihad-al-Islami. A letter sent to a Pakistan-based journalist for *Asia Times* allegedly from Al-Qaeda's Ilyas Kashmiri, with connections to Hyderabad-based terror suspects, warned foreign competitors to keep away from the World Cup hockey, the IPL and the Commonwealth Games.

More bad news continues on another channel: the protest by news television channels against what they call random guidelines and contentious clauses regarding IPL footage. Senior News Broadcasters Association (NBA) executives were kept waiting for an hour when they travelled to Mumbai for a meeting with IPL bosses which lasted five minutes. The NBA wants IPL guidelines agreed upon in 2008 but Sony President Rohit Gupta said the footage issue was "a discussion point which will be sorted out within a week".

Modi, unsurprisingly, refuses to be cowed down. The moment the International Olympic Committee recognised cricket, he lost no time to preen, claiming he would take cricket to the US. Inquiries about the IPL were, he said, "pouring in from film stars, industrialists, NRIs and a substantial number of foreign organisations". Maybe he believes in a 'home and abroad' event every other year will emerge as the IPL's distinctive feature.

Rosaiah has another view: "Changing venues in this manner makes the country seem unsafe and sends wrong signals to global investors." Raman denied rumours of a diaspora-friendly IPL, telling *INDIA TODAY*, "I don't think we are looking at the IPL as a travelling circus. It is a part of what the new modern India is and no matter what has happened, we have managed to keep our heads above water."

A sound argument, but the IPL is only in its third year and sometimes it looks like that water may just turn into a tsunami.

with Sharda Ugra